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Sustainability is no longer a buzzword—it is a necessity for businesses today. Suresh Narayanan, Chairman and Managing Director of Nestlé India, talks to Karishma Asoodani about the FMCG major's commitment to the environment. From its century-old relationship with Indian farmers to ambitious net-zero targets and cutting-edge eco-initiatives, Narayanan highlights how sustainability is embedded in Nestlé India's DNA. Edited excerpts:

Q: How do you envision the role of leadership in driving sustainability in a country like India?

A: I think the role of leadership is more than just guiding the fortunes of a corporation. The role of leadership is also to instil a sense of hope, action and sustainability for corporate operations. And, in so far as it impacts the environment, it is an important role. Nestlé is blessed across the world with millions and millions of consumers for our brands. I think there is an inherent responsibility of the company not just in terms of shareholders but also in terms of the community and society we live in and that's why sustainability has been such an important part of our journey.

Q: Can you share Nestlé India's sustainability plans over the years given your long association with the brand?

A: Nestlé India has a century-long relationship

with consumers, starting in 1912 as a small trading operation to becoming a major FMCG (fast-moving consumer goods) company. Behind brands like Maggi, KitKat, Nescafé and Munch is a strong agricultural connection. For example, 80,000–100,000 farmers in Punjab have worked with us for decades in dairy. Our Nescafé plant in Kodagu, Karnataka, sources sustainably from 5,000 coffee growers, and Maggi relies on 1,000–1,500 spice farmers across Gujarat, Rajasthan and Andhra Pradesh practicing sustainable farming. This farmer-company link is what we call responsible sourcing—a key pillar of sustainability that ensures high-quality, sustainably sourced raw materials for the long term.

Q: Has your sustainability journey changed over the last decade?

A: Sustainability must be in a company's DNA—it's a need, not something in a checkbox. I've been with Nestlé for 26 years, and even before, the company tracked key performance indicators (KPIs) on greenhouse gases, water, energy and effluents. Sustainable farming, packaging, manufacturing and logistics have been integral to our operations for decades, with impact scaling up over time. | 13

“We aim to be the best-in-class in sustainability, but never lose sight of affordability and relevance for consumers”

Q: Does focusing on sustainability make it harder to manage operating costs?

A: Sustainability is essential, but consumers don't pay extra for it. Their choices reflect how responsible they perceive a company to be. Inflation adds pressure on raw material and sustainability costs, but Nestlé benefits from economies of scale, advanced science and technology and strategic procurement to manage costs. Pricing adjustments happen only if needed, but sustainability commitments, both global and local, are never compromised.